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The Plain Dealer | Breaking news: cleveland.com

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GIRLS
BASKETBALLBlazers
hold on
for winBOB FORTUNA
Plain Dealer Reporter

It wasn't pretty as far as Division II regional championship basketball games go, but to the Hathaway Brown girls, it turned out to be a masterpiece.

Watching an 11-point lead slide by the wayside late in the fourth quarter, the Blazers regrouped to edge Canal Fulton Northwest, 56-54, Friday night at Barborton and earn their first trip to next week's state tournament.

"It hasn't sunk in yet, I'm still a little bit numb," said Blazers coach Paul Barlow. "I guess the only word I can use is indescribable."

What happened in the game's final 2:41 was close to unbelievable.

Northwest junior Alexis Harkins made a three-point play to tie it, 50-50, and erase a 45-34 lead Hathaway Brown owned just four minutes earlier.

Angela Groves' foul shot gave the Blazers (21-4) back the lead at 51-50 with 1:44 left before teammate Mylan Woods made good on an underhanded layup off an Alexis Dobbs' steal to push Hathaway Brown's lead to 53-50.

The Indians came back to pull within 53-52 on Becky White's 5-foot jumper with 55.4 seconds left, only to have Hathaway Brown answer 23 seconds later when Dobbs made the front part of a two-shot foul. Dobbs then canned both ends of a two-shot foul with 12.4 seconds remaining to seal it for the Blazers.

"We were definitely working hard for the rebounds, but it was pretty tough inside," said Groves, a 6-1 junior, who grabbed a game-high 12 rebounds, blocked five shots and tied Woods for top scoring honors with 12 points.

"But this feels wonderful."

What wasn't wonderful was the 50 total turnovers, 73 total trips to the foul line and because 53 total fouls were called, neither team was able to get into a rhythm.

"Both teams are up-tempo, and like to play 94-feet, man-for-man defense," Barlow said. "But both of us also got hurt by guard penetration and that caused both teams to get into foul trouble."

"I think we got a little bit rattled and our inexperience did not ever getting this far might have shown a bit. [Northwest] turned us over a couple of times and they got some easy baskets but down the stretch, Dobbs made some crucial free throws. She's been ice water two games in a row."

Dobbs had nine points, four assists, two steals and committed just one turnover.

Northwest (21-5) had Amber McKinney and Becky White finish with 12 and 10 points, respectively.

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TIM HARRISON | SPECIAL TO THE PLAIN DEALER

Hoban senior Tenishia Benson goes for a layup guarded by Perkins junior Cierra Bravard during the Knights' loss Friday in the Ontario Division II Regional championship.

GIRLS BASKETBALL REGIONAL FINAL

Hoban's cold spurt spells doom

TODD STUMPF
Special to The Plain Dealer

ONTARIO, OHIO — For all its complexities, basketball is still a simple game. Put the ball in the basket and you will be successful. Don't, and you won't.

Archbishop Hoban's girls basketball team learned that lesson the hard way Friday night. Despite being better at just about everything else, the Knights' inability to make shots proved their undoing in a 42-28 loss to Sandusky Perkins in the Ontario Division II Regional championship.

Perkins (21-3) moves on to play Thursday in the Division II state semifinals at Value City Arena in Columbus. Hoban, a surprise winner of the Lake District, finished 20-5.

"We didn't shoot very well," said Hoban senior Tenishia Benson, who led the Knights with 11 points. "I thought our defense was incredible. That definitely wasn't what hurt us."

PERKINS
HOBAN42
28

Hoban, which trailed nearly throughout, started the second half with a 7-2 run to pull within 23-20 with 3:22 left in the third quarter. At that point, the lid closed. Over the next 7:40, the Knights made just one field goal.

Even then, Hoban was still within six points after Benson's layup with just under three minutes left. The Knights would not score again.

"We got solid looks at the basket, they just didn't fall," Hoban coach Tracy Miller said. "I can't complain about our offense. But you won't beat many teams shooting 12-of-53 from the field."

It was even a bit worse than that. Hoban made just 12-of-56 shots for 21 percent. The Knights were 1-for-15 from 3-point range.

That was the theme all night. Over the final three periods, Hoban shot 17 percent (8-of-46), so all the defense in the world wasn't going to make a difference.

Outside of shooting, the Knights were

at worst the Pirates' equal. Hoban's pressure kept Perkins from establishing much offensively. Perkins turned the ball over 19 times to just 10 for the Knights.

The Pirates attempted just seven shots in the second half, but did enough damage from the foul line to keep a safe distance ahead. They made 15-of-24 free-throw attempts in the second half, many down the stretch as Hoban fouled to try to stay in the game.

Senior Shantel Lawler added nine points for Hoban. Sophomore Rachel Tecca had six points, nine rebounds and seven steals for the Knights.

Perkins' 6-4 All-Ohio junior center Cierra Bravard, whose presence attracted coaches from several major Division I colleges, led all scorers with 18 points.

A back-and-forth first quarter ended with Perkins leading, 11-9. Hoban's only lead of the game, 5-3, came with 4:49 left in the opening period.

Todd Stumpf is a free-lance writer from Stow.

BOYS BASKETBALL DISTRICT FINALS

Clutch play, big win

Olmsted Falls
finishes strong
over Holy NameBOB MIGRA
Plain Dealer Reporter

Tyler Sparks knows a few things about winning.

OLMSTED FALLS 56
HOLY NAME 50

The Olmsted Falls senior, who was responsible for so many big plays as the Bulldogs' quarterback, showed that his clutch play is not limited to the football field on Friday nights.

Sparks scored 11 of Olmsted Falls' 13 points in the fourth quarter to help hold off a strong challenge from Holy Name in the Division II boys basketball district championship in front of a standing-room-only crowd of 1,300 at Westlake.

Sparks finished with 25 points in a 56-50 victory.

"We had the guy we wanted to get the ball to at the end of the game and he delivered big time," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said.

Several times during the game, Olmsted Falls seemed poised to pull away, only to see the Green Wave rally. The fourth quarter was no different. Sparks gave the Bulldogs a 45-39 lead with a layup, but Holy Name stormed back on 3-point goals by Anthony Ghanem and Tom Krakowiak, and a foul shot by Ghanem, to take a 46-45 lead, with 3:41 left.

Sparks then hit a jump shot and a 3-point shot for a 50-46 lead. His two foul shots with 44 seconds left pushed the lead to 52-48.

"That's a great team," Sparks said. "I don't think you get a feel for how good they are until you're out there playing against them."

Holy Name again cut the deficit to two, 52-50, on two foul shots by Danny Day (11 points, nine rebounds), but Mike Stallard and Sparks each hit two foul shots in the closing seconds as dozens of fans in the Olmsted Falls student section held up "16" signs, signifying the Bulldogs' return to the Sweet 16.

Olmsted Falls (21-2) will play the winner from the Barborton district on Thursday at the Canton Fieldhouse. It will be the ninth regional trip under Donahue. The last was in 2004, in Division I.

Pat Pellerite seconded Sparks' big night, with 16 points.



GUS CHAN | THE PLAIN DEALER

Olmsted Falls' Alex Sedlay, left, and Kyle Bungard celebrate the Bulldogs' Division II district championship victory Friday over Holy Name at Westlake.

Game Balls

Vote for Friday's top boys basketball performer on cleveland.com/Hr Voting is open until noon Tuesday. Check Sunday's Sports section for a girls basketball Game Balls contest from Friday and Saturday regional final action. See who won both polls each Thursday in The Locker Room.

The contenders:

Jeff Spikes, Harvey

Senior center scored 11 points with 11 rebounds, five blocks and five steals in a 49-39 win over West Geauga.

Holy Name finished 18-5.

"Nobody gave us a chance here, but we gave ourselves a chance," Holy Name coach Mark Krakowiak said. "We thought we could play with Olmsted Falls. I'm proud of the effort. We responded [when behind] that way all year. They never hang their heads."

Ghanem led the Green Wave with 16 points, including four 3-point shots. Krakowiak scored 10 points.

Tyler Sparks, Olmsted Falls

Senior guard went 7-for-9 from the foul line and finished with 25 points in a 56-50 win over Holy Name.

Maurice Haynes, VASJ

Senior forward scored 11 points, pulled down 10 rebounds and had three blocks in a 59-31 win over Berkshire.

Phil Workman, Windham

Junior guard had 10 second-quarter points en route to 17 total in a 55-44 win over Maplewood.

Andrew Hofener, Lutheran West

Senior center scored 18 points in a 71-64 win over St. Peter Chanel.

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Longhorns
rally past
FirebirdsCARL MATZELLE
Plain Dealer Reporter

In 1998, the most recent time Lutheran West won a boys basketball district championship, the Longhorns went all the way to the Final Four in Columbus.

It took a little while for Lutheran to ignite in its 71-64 come-from-behind victory over No. 2 seed St. Peter Chanel on Friday, but coach Phil Argento said he thinks history can definitely repeat itself.

"Why not?" said Argento, who shared the Associated Press All-Northeast Lakes District Division III Coach of the Year honors with Pymatuning Valley's Jeremy Huber. "We lost to Brooklyn in 1998 and made the final four. Brooklyn broke our [61-game] regular-season streak this year. Anything's possible."

Both teams appeared nervous in the early going in the Division III district final at Elyria High School, missing easy layups and jump shots and turning the ball over.

The defending champion Firebirds were without 6-11 center and Cleveland State recruit Joe Latas, who's recovering from a broken ankle. But senior guard Brendon Coyne took charge in the first quarter, scoring 11 points and Chanel led, 18-7, after one period. Sophomore point guard Arthur Jordan added 13 of his game-leading 19 points in the first half, and the Firebirds' full-court press stifled Lutheran West through halftime, 35-26.

The Longhorns — led by seniors Andy Hofener and Jacob O'Hara and junior Scott Voiers, who combined for 46 points — fought back in the third quarter, attacking the basket and rebounding. Junior guard Andrew Thomas' 3-pointer cut the Firebirds' lead to 56-54 with 3:55 left, and Hofener's slam made it 57-56 with 2:57 to go in the game, Lutheran's first lead.

Chanel kept fouling O'Hara, who made 7 of 8 free throws in the final period to ice it.

"They shut us down in the first half; we couldn't get into the post," Hofener said. "But our outside shots kept us in the game, and we decided to attack the middle after that."

Lutheran also held 6-5 sophomore center Lamar McKnight to five points. Chanel senior point guard Nick Russo was another story. Russo finished with 15 points, including four 3-pointers. Sophomore guard Ryan Betori also added 13, but it wasn't enough.

Lutheran West has now won six in a row since Brooklyn ended its 61-game regular season streak on Feb. 9, 71-67.

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BOYS BASKETBALL ROUNDUP

Vikings overwhelm Badgers

From staff reports

The top-seeded Villa Angela-St. Joseph boys basketball team turned its district final into a 59-31 romp Friday night after leading Berkshire, 7-4, entering the second quarter.

The Vikings (16-7) scored 35 points over the second and third quarters of the Division III title game at Lakeland Community College to turn away the sixth-seeded Badgers, who committed 19 turnovers.

Junior guard/forward Ashen Ward led all players with 14 points. Senior center/forward Maurice Haynes added 11 points and 10 rebounds. Junior center Klein Harper had 7 points and 11 rebounds.

Nick Cichon led Berkshire with 10 points.

The Vikings advance to a Canton Regional, where they will play Manchester.

Harvey 49, West Geauga 39

The top-seeded Red Raiders are known for their ability to run the floor and overwhelm opponents with a flurry of points, but they won their third straight district championship with a stout defense.

The Red Raiders, winners of 23 straight games since a season-opening three-point loss to St. Vincent-St. Mary, will play in a regional semifinal at the Canton Civic Center on Thursday after claiming the Division II district crown at Madison.

Harvey will face the winner of tonight's game between Canfield and Poland Seminary.

Senior point guard Scott Aston scored 17 points for Harvey. Jeff Spikes, a 6-7, 285-pound center, had 11 points, 11 rebounds, five blocked shots and five steals. West Geauga (17-5) was seeded second.

—Mike Petica

Manchester 55, Northwest-ern 53 The Panthers rallied

from a 40-34 third-quarter deficit to knock off the top-seeded team in the Division III district title game at Wooster.

No. 3 Manchester outscored Northwestern, 21-13, in the fourth quarter.

Senior Blake Marsh scored a team-high 14 points.

The Panthers advance to a Canton Regional, where they will play VASJ.

Windham 55, Maplewood 44

The Bombers won their 20th game, claiming the Division IV Warren district crown behind guard Phil Workman's 17 points, six assists and five steals.

Top-seeded Windham led, 27-21, at halftime and overcame foul trouble after picking up seven first-quarter fouls.

Fourth-seeded Maplewood ends its season at 16-9.

Windham (20-3) advances to a Canton Regional, where it will face the winner of today's district final at Byesville.

HIGH SCHOOL SCOREBOARD

BOYS BASKETBALL

District finals

Division II

MADISON

At Madison High School

(2) West Geauga 32 12 6 9-39

(1) Harvey 10 10 11 18-49

West Geauga (17-5); Harvey 2-2-4, Doss and 4-6-9, Wright 1-0-3, Murawski 4-1-9, King 2-0-8, Walsh 1-1-1.

(3) St. Peter Chanel 3-2-6, Paratore Harvey 2-0-8, Soltes 5-1-11.

WESTLAKE

At Westlake High School

(2) Holy Name 14 14 11 11-50

(1) Olmsted Falls 11 10 13 13-56

Holy Name (18-5); West 4-1-4, Donahue 4-1-4, Ghanem 5-2-16, Krakowiak 4-0-10, Day 4-3-11.

Olmsted Falls (21-2); Stallard 1-2-4, Bungard 0-1-1, D. Pellerite 5-5-16, Sparks 0-7-5, Donahue 2-0-4, P. Pellerite 2-0-4.

Division III

ELYRIA

At Elyria High School

(1) Lutheran West 7 10 17 28-71

(3) St. Peter Chanel 18 17 10 19-64

Lutheran West (21-4); Vaters 4-0-14, Sparks 3-1-4, Thomas 4-2-12, Mancini 3-1-7, Fackler 1-0-1, Yelton 1-0-2, Hofener 1-0-18, Semel 1-0-2.

St. Peter Chanel (16-7); Russo 5-1-15, Coyne 5-0-11, Jordan 0-2-19, Betori 4-4-11, Brown 5-1-11, McKnight 2-1-5.

LAKELAND

At Lakeland Community College

(1) Berkshire 4 7 10 10-31

(3) VASJ 7 10 18 17-59

Berkshire (16-7); Barnes 4-0-8, Ward 6-0-14, Haynes 5-1-11, Harper 3-1-7, Szczepinski 2-1-6, Goodrum 0-1-1, Madrox 1-0-2, Morgan 2-0-4, Freeman 5-1-1, Jenkins 2-0-4.

Villa Angela-St. Joseph (16-7); Barnes 4-0-8, Ward 6-0-14, Haynes 5-1-11, Harper 3-1-7, Szczepinski 2-1-6, Goodrum 0-1-1, Madrox 1-0-2, Morgan 2-0-4, Freeman 5-1-1, Jenkins 2-0-4.

At Salem High School

Campbell Memorial 69, (1) Ursuline 63

HOUSTON

At Wooster High School

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